



Unpacking Process Anti-Patterns

Lessons from Ideation to Delivery

Kyle Jenkins – kyle.jenkins@improving.com

The problem is
always a **process**
never a person

Defining a “Process Anti-Pattern”

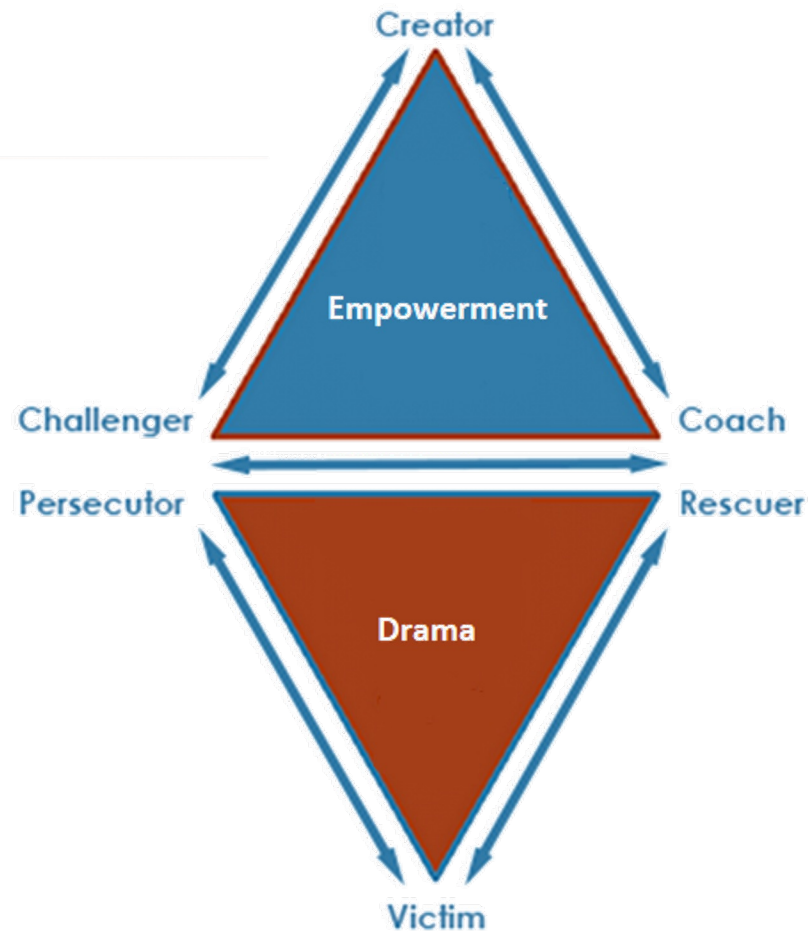
A **recurring** workflow or practice that consistently **undermines** delivery, collaboration, or business outcomes.

These negatively impact workplace culture.

Goals

Identify Process flow issues that you may or may not have seen yet.

Stay in the creative mindset: what are you able to do now when you see these?



Career

The Beginning – Hiring

Process Anti–Pattern #1: Prioritizing hard skills above all else

“I’m looking for a
<tech> dev”

“I’m looking for a
job using <tech>”



The Beginning – Hiring

Process Anti–Pattern #1: Prioritizing hard skills above all else

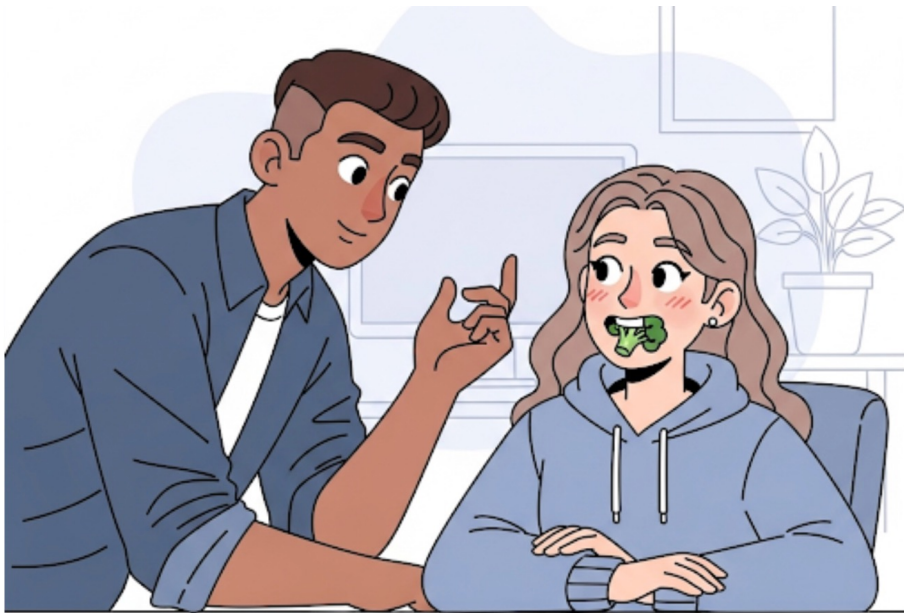
- ✦ Values
- ✦ Creative Mindset
- ✦ Industry Alignment
- ✦ Humble / Hungry / People Smart*
- ✦ Skills



* Ideal Team Player – Patrick Lencioni

Feedback

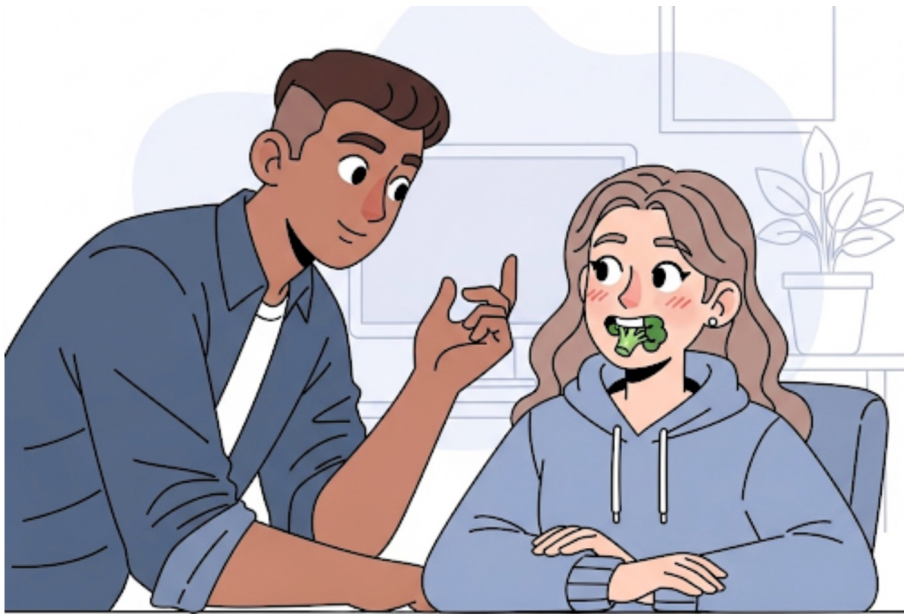
Process Anti–Pattern #2: Yearly is too long... so is monthly



- ✦ When something needs to be corrected, you need feedback ASAP
- ✦ When conflict exists, it needs to be resolved ASAP

Feedback

Process Anti-Pattern #2: Yearly is too long... so is monthly



For Others

✦ "clear is kind; unclear is unkind"

– *Dr. Brené Brown*

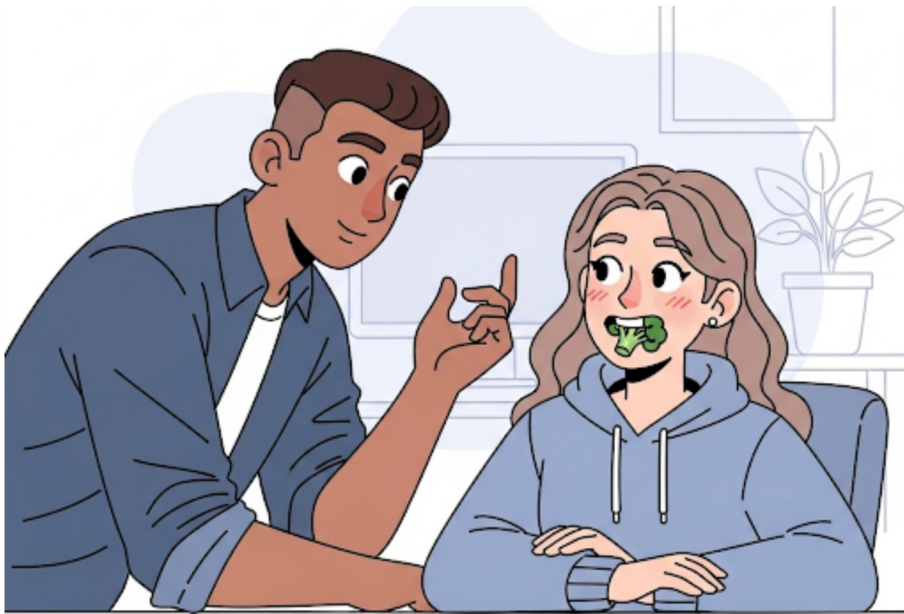
✦ Mean what you say, don't say it mean

✦ Peer to Peer feedback

✦ Help find solutions

Feedback

Process Anti–Pattern #2: Yearly is too long... so is monthly



When Received

- ✦ Show appreciation
- ✦ Apologize quickly
- ✦ Follow through with correction

Pre-emptive: Self Gathering

- ✦ 360 Assessments
 - ✦ Values
- ✦ Reflection

Onboarding

Process Anti-Pattern #3: Follow these docs... good luck!



- ✦ Wastes time for unnecessary problem solving
- ✦ Feels like “bothering” to ask someone for help
- ✦ Communicates Silos from the start
- ✦ Time to Value suffers

Onboarding

Process Anti-Pattern #3: Follow these docs... good luck!



- * Pair
 - * Sit next to them
 - * Stay on a call
- * Videos for projects/architecture
- * Get together as a team

Documentation

Process Anti-Pattern #4: The Documentation Black Hole

Signs of poor documentation

- ✦ Can't find it
- ✦ No decision logs
- ✦ Out of date
- ✦ Duplication
- ✦ Hour long recorded videos of meetings

"Working Software over Comprehensive documentation"



Documentation

Process Anti–Pattern #4: The Documentation Black Hole

Wiki Docs: 2 Types

- ✦ Living Documentation
 - ✦ Review once a month
 - ✦ Be picky
 - ✦ Small Videos
- ✦ Point in Time
 - ✦ Archive only
 - ✦ Decision Documents
 - ✦ Search labels

Versioning is good;
Permission is bad;



Documentation

Process Anti-Pattern #4: The Documentation Black Hole

Code Documentation

- ✦ Application Code
 - ✦ Code Docs
 - ✦ Readmes next to code
- ✦ Libraries
 - ✦ Code Docs
 - ✦ Site (ex. Storybook)



Promotions

Process Anti-Pattern #5: Promotion into failure (Peter Principle)



Promotion Problems

- ✦ Wrong Reasons
 - ✦ Single Track Career
 - ✦ Voice over the team
 - ✦ Money
- ✦ Lack of Training
- ✦ Lack of Competency
- ✦ Best Individual Contributor
SO....

Promotions

Process Anti-Pattern #5: Promotion into failure (Peter Principal)

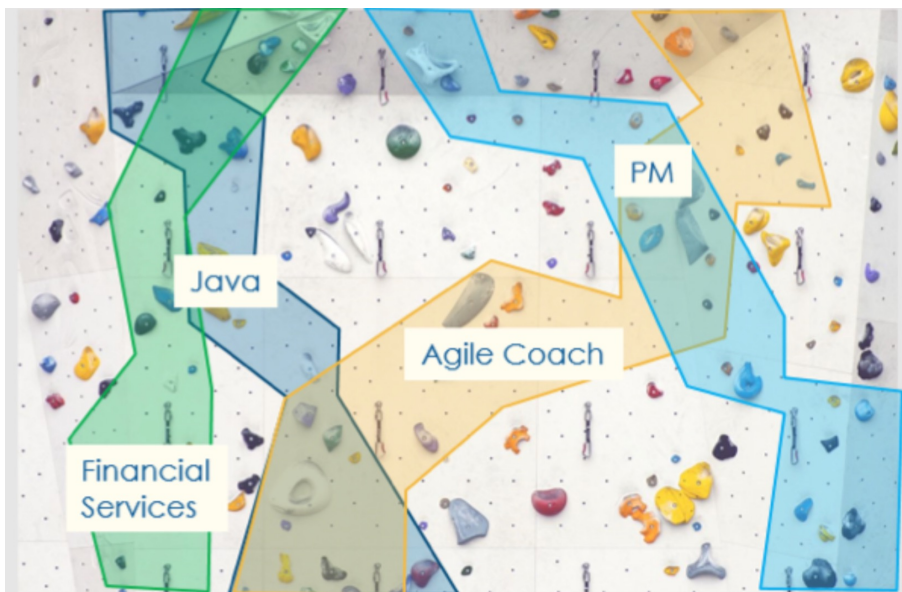


Self Solutions

- ✦ Ask your self “Would I still take this if it was a 5% pay cut?”
- ✦ Fully comprehend the position
 - ✦ Measurable Expectations

Promotions

Process Anti-Pattern #5: Promotion into failure (Peter Principal)

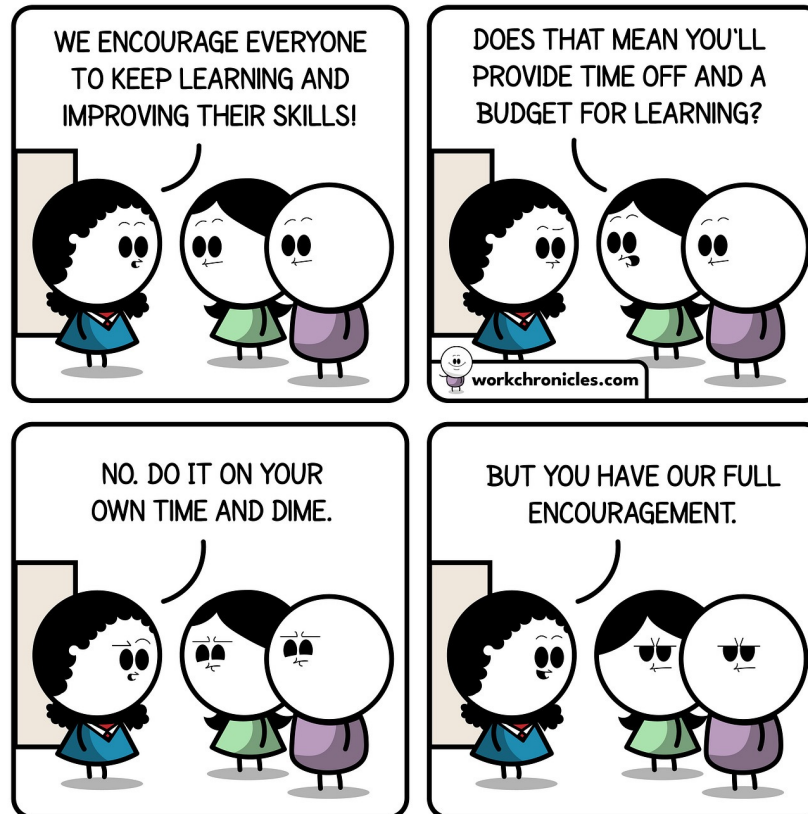


Holistic Solutions

- ✦ Achievement Driven
- ✦ Multiple Tracks
- ✦ Fluid Tracks
 - ✦ What does <title> <name> look like?
- ✦ 360 Reviews

Education (and lack thereof)

Process Anti-Pattern #6: Expectations of Educational Support

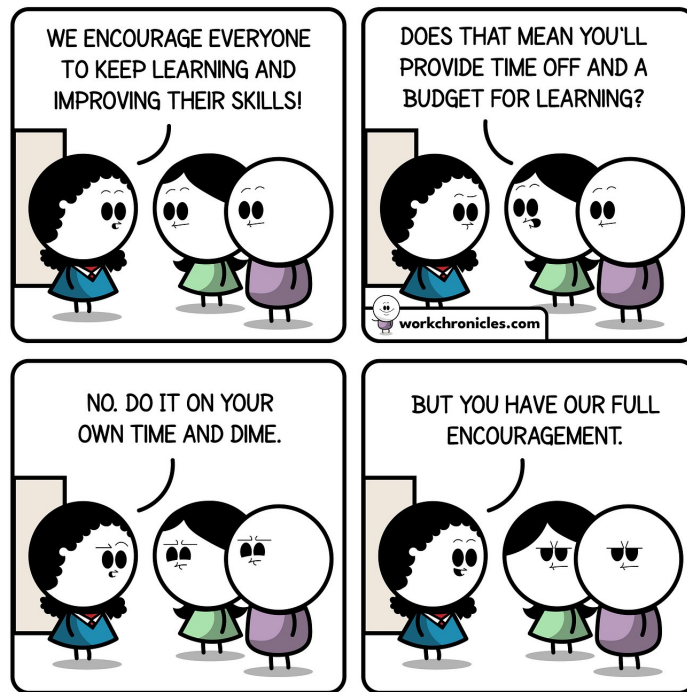


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Work Chronicles
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Education (and lack thereof)

Process Anti-Pattern #6: Expectations of Educational Support



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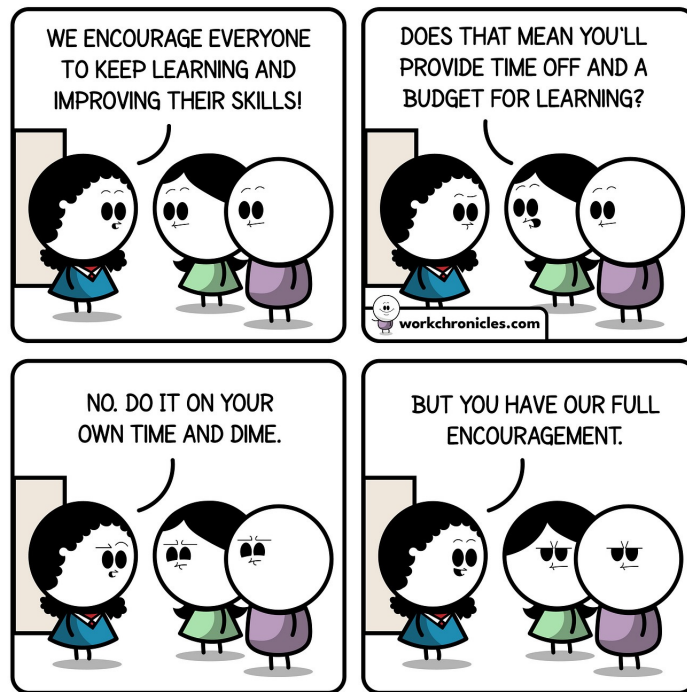
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Nice to have “benefits”

- ✦ Coursera / Udemy / etc.
- ✦ Book Reimbursements
- ✦ Certification Reimbursement
- ✦ Higher Level Education Reimbursement
- ✦ Conference Reimbursement

Education (and lack thereof)

Process Anti-Pattern #6: Expectations of Educational Support



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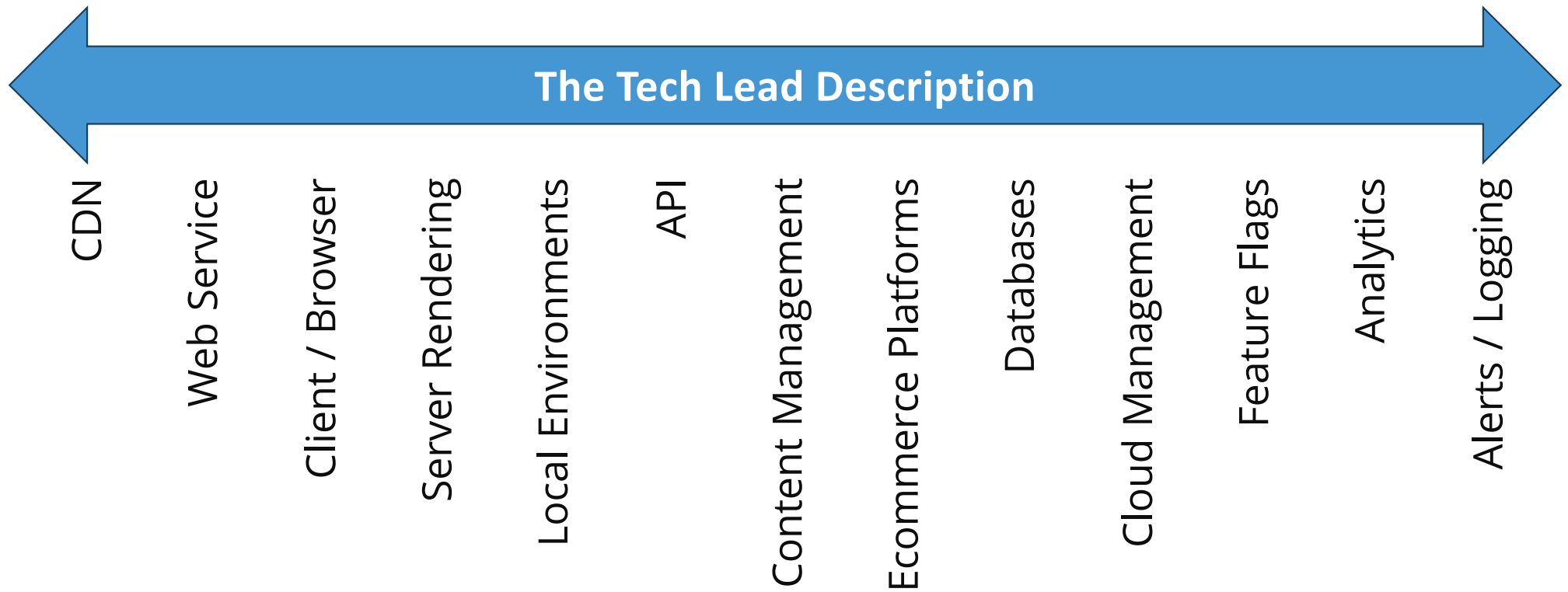
Goal 5 hours per week of growth

Free/Cheap Ideas for growth:

- ✦ Podcasts
- ✦ Audiobooks (Libby [free])
- ✦ Projects
- ✦ User Groups / Conference
- ✦ Speaking
- ✦ Webinars

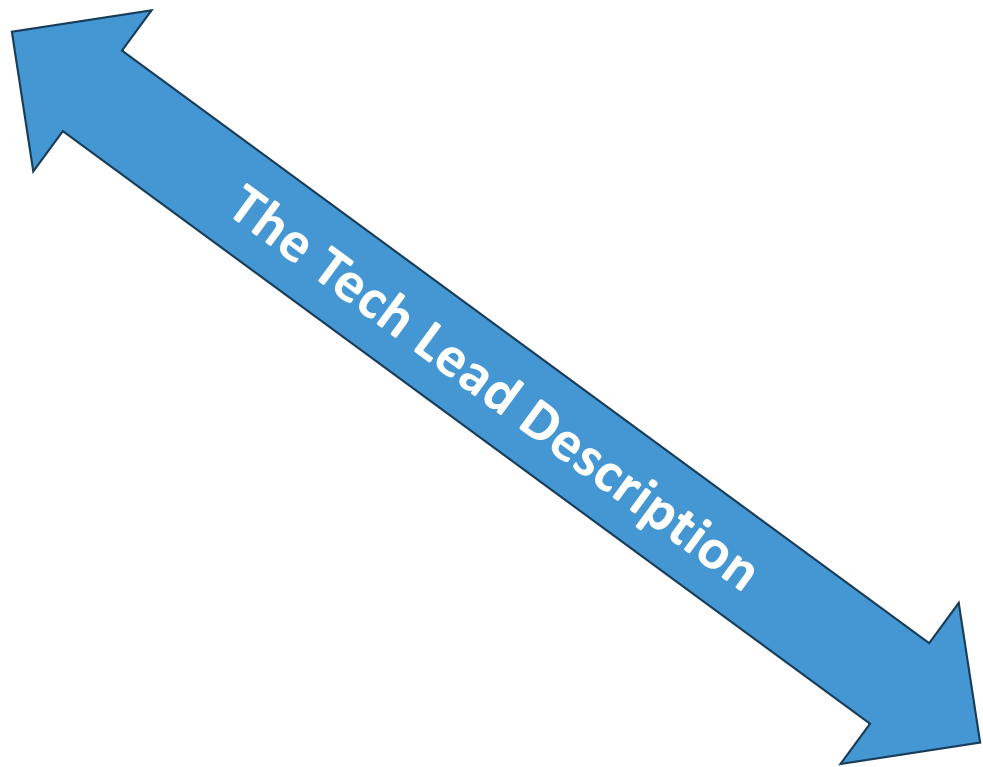
T Shape Education

Process Anti–Pattern #7: Lack of creating a full stack experience



T Shape Education

Process Anti–Pattern #7: Lack of full stack experience



- ✦ Interact with other teams!!!!
- ✦ Take intentional time to understand the other systems
- ✦ Self Projects

Agile

The fix for everything... right?

Agile

Finds the process problems to fix

What is Agile?

agilemanifesto.org

Manifesto for Agile Software Development

Principles behind the Agile Manifesto

Agile

Process Anti-Pattern #8: Forcing Agile into Existing Processes



Planning & Scope Friction

- ✦ "Invisible" Work and Unmeasured Technical Debt
- ✦ Inability to Estimate based on Velocity

Execution & Delivery Bottlenecks

- ✦ Late-Stage QA and Testing Deficits
- ✦ Infrequent, High-Risk Deployments
- ✦ Siloed "Heroics"

Feedback & Alignment Breakdown

- ✦ Work-In-Progress (WIP) Overload

Agile

Process Anti-Pattern #8: Forcing Agile into Existing Processes



Start with yourself

- ✦ Track start to “done” on tickets
- ✦ Track your start to “production” on tickets (Lead Time)
- ✦ Daily+ Communication on what is/will be done

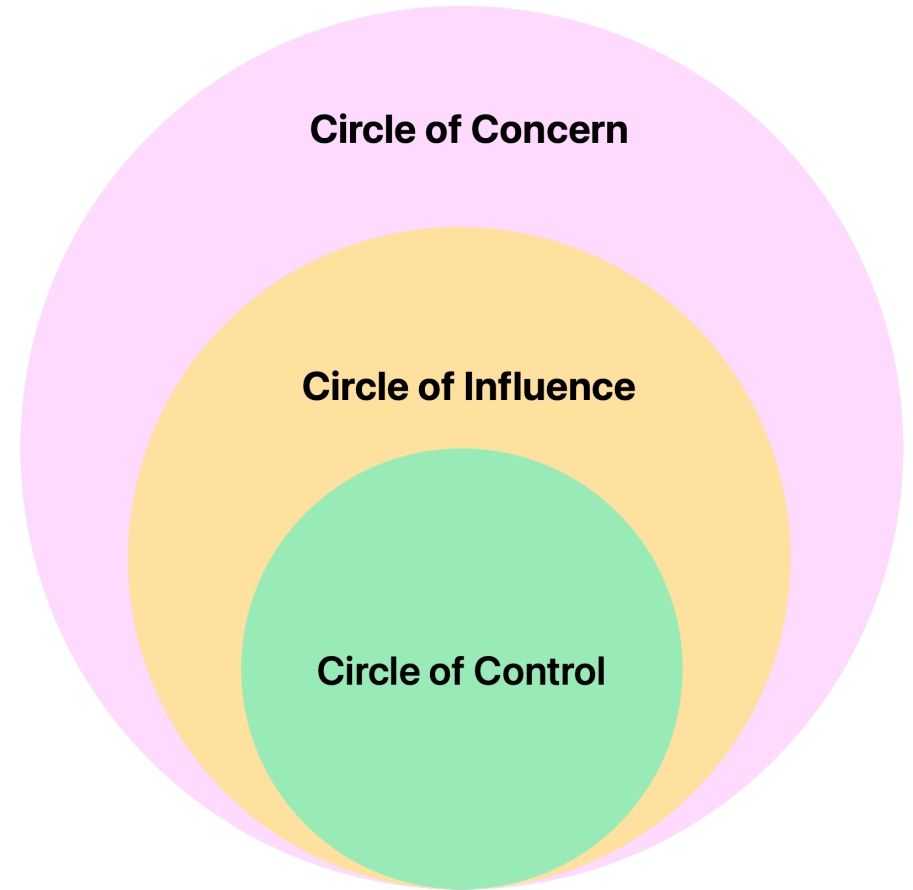
Focus your retrospective feedback on shrinking those

Ask yourself: *what would be needed to change to make that task take less than one day?*

Retrospective

Process Anti–Pattern #9: Lack of Autonomy

The team cannot create changes around topics brought up by retrospectives



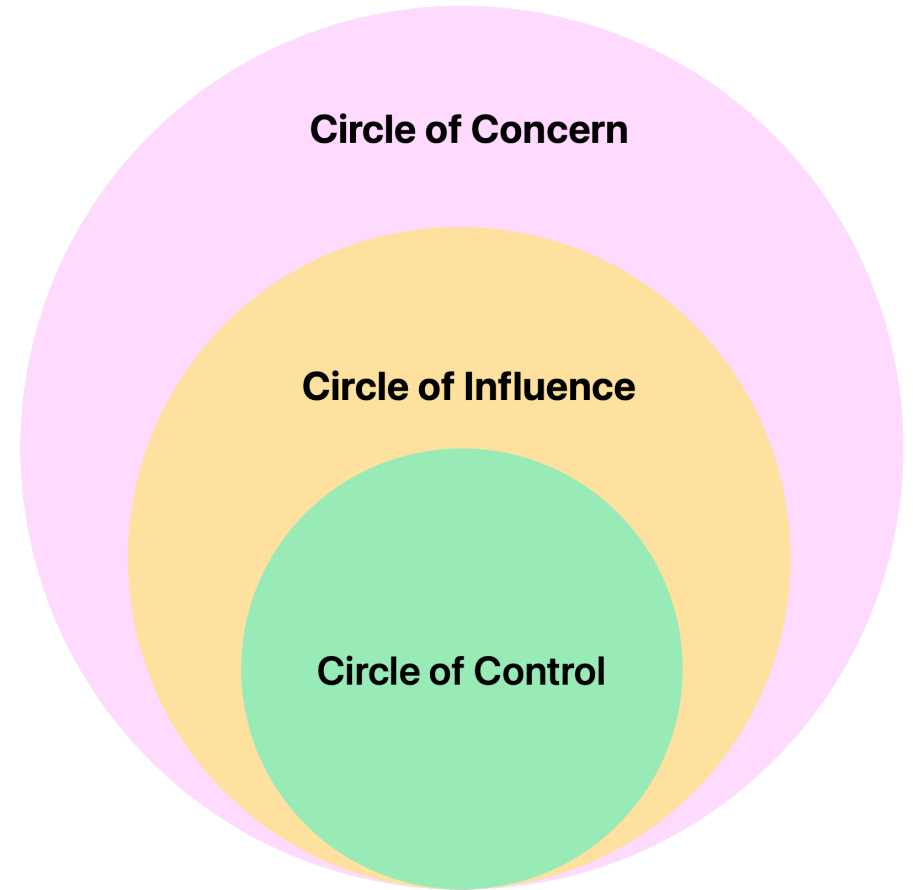
Agile Retrospective

Process Anti–Pattern #9: Lack of Autonomy

Focus on what is within your control

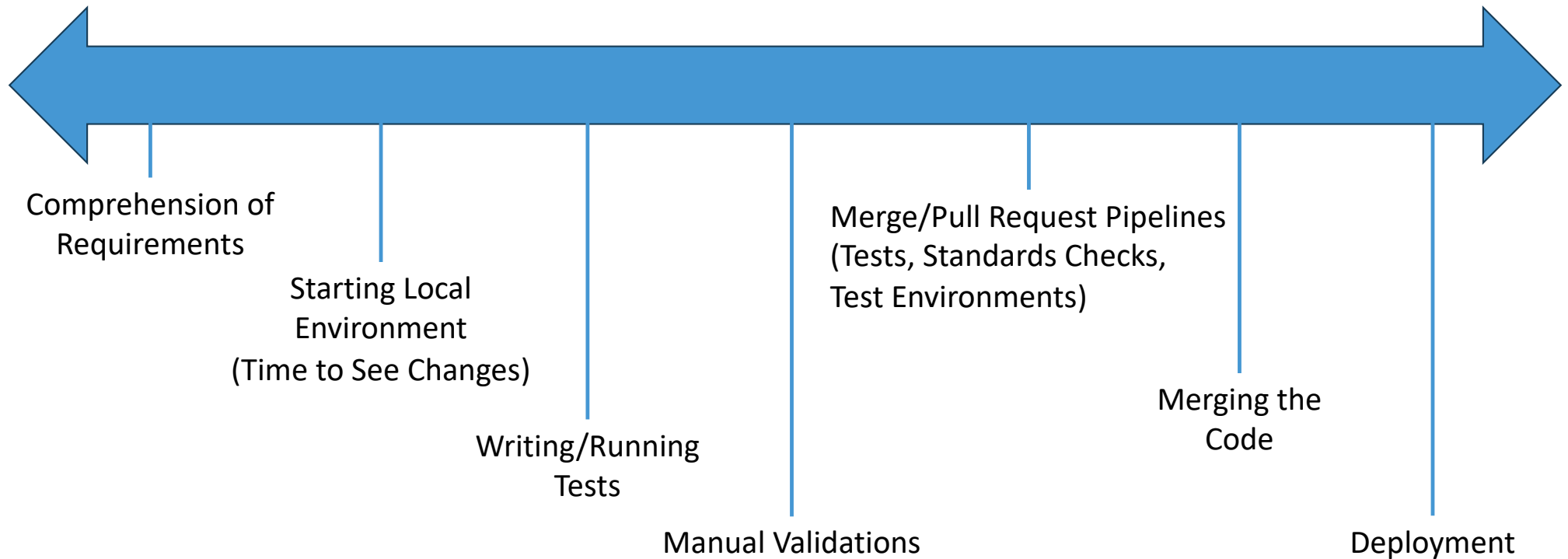
Educate yourself, and share, around circle of influence

Avoid Blame



Lead Time

What is everything in Lead Time?



Development

User Experience

Process Anti-Pattern #10: Missing UX Domain Knowledge

1 to 5 pixels is unlikely to reduce sales

The fear is real: "if it doesn't get done now, it won't ever get done"



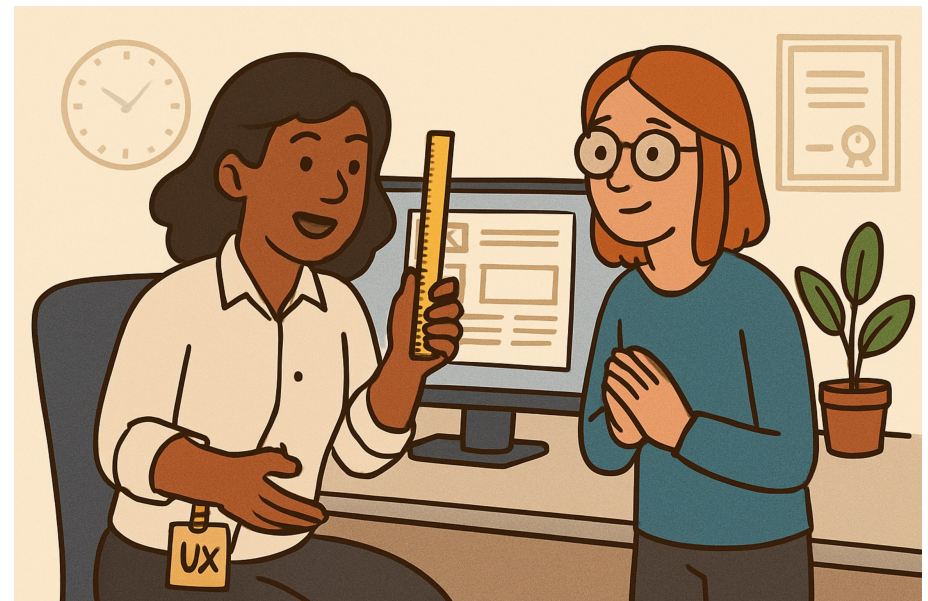
User Experience

Process Anti-Pattern #10: Missing UX Domain Knowledge

Study basic design concepts
(CRAP Design)

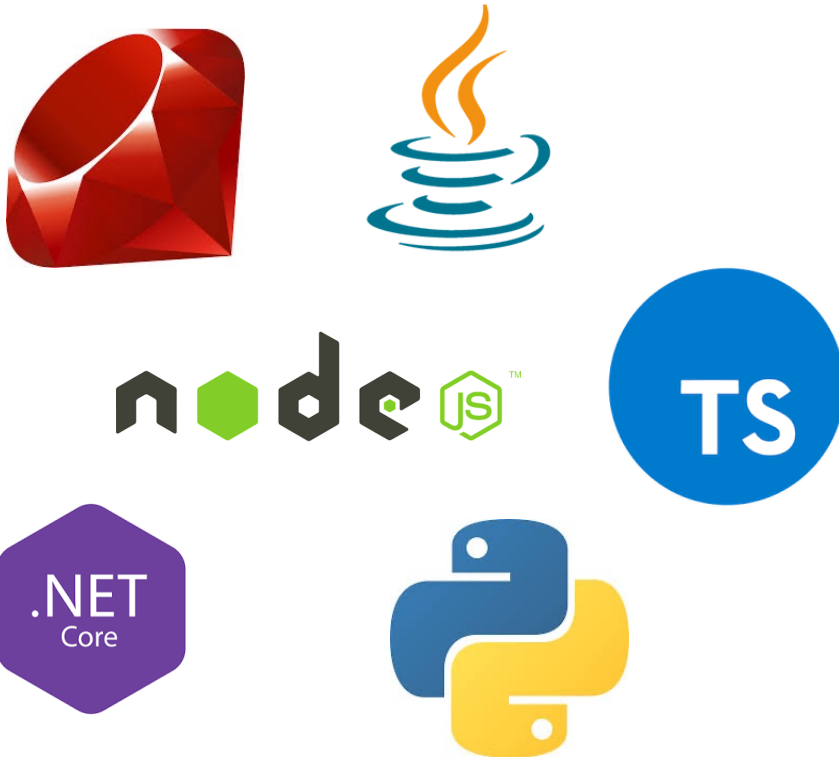
Have discussion during
development around the
design

Understand how to develop
around the design principles
and goals



Coding

Process Anti–Pattern #11: Not using what's in front of you



Don't assume the tech in front of you is bad, learn it first.

- ✦ Understand the build process
- ✦ Simple ways of refactoring
- ✦ Listen to the code
 - ✦ Tests
 - ✦ Types
- ✦ Setup your IDE

Fear of AI

Process Anti–Pattern #12: Not Communicating AI with a Creative Mindset



Productivity tooling will continue to advance

Engineers do not just write code

Engineers solve problems and implement solutions



Find Free Food Near You

Search community fridges, food pantries, meal programs, and gardens on an interactive map with filters and directions.

☒ Active Only

☐ Open Now

☐ Has Photos

☐ Types

Shortcuts

Search Radius 25 miles

5 mi

10 mi

25 mi

50 mi

100 mi

Any

☐ Resources within 25 miles of your location will be shown

Resources Located Near Me: 675

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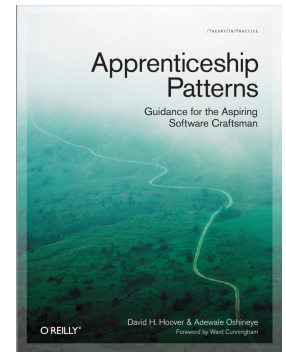
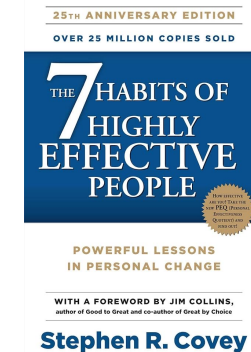
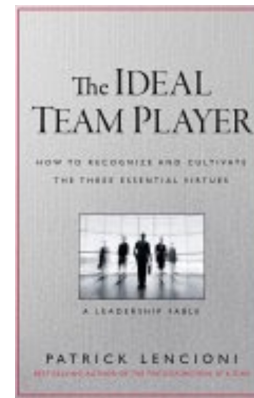
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Reading List

Agile Manifesto – agilemanifesto.org

Work Chronicles Comics – workchronicles.com



Apprenticeship Patterns - David H. Hoover & Adewale Oshineye

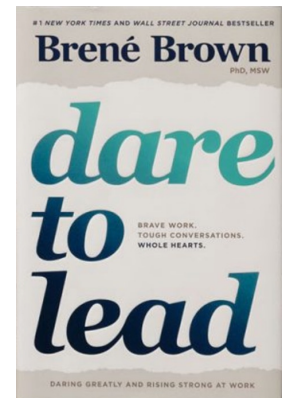
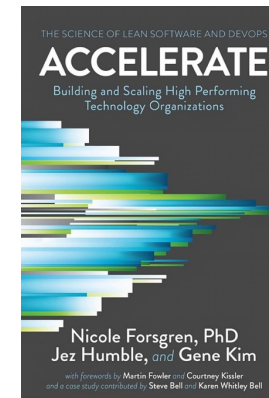
7 Habits of Highly Effective People – Stephen R. Covey

Ideal Team Player – Patrick Lencioni

Dare to Lead – Brené Brown

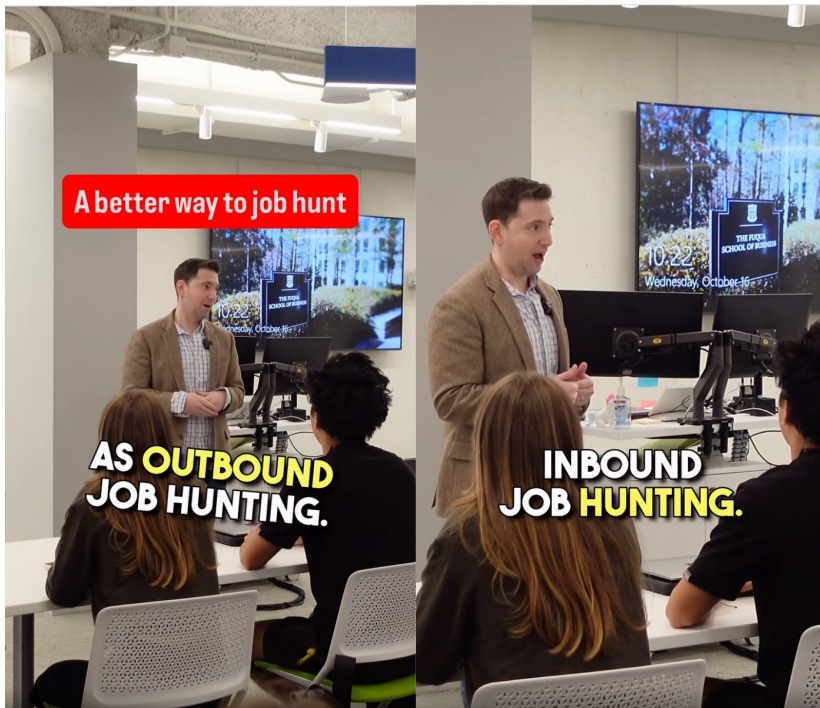
Accelerate – Nicole Forsgren, Jez Humble, Gene Kim

Great at Work - Morten T. Hansen



Bonus: Career

Process Anti–Pattern Bonus: Outbound Job Hunting



What are you doing NOW so jobs seek you in 4 years?

Youtube: @drdinin

**What other anti-process
patterns do you seek
answers to?**